

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

Move Like Harlem

Grades 5–8 · Physical Education · The Lindy Hop, the Charleston and the Savoy Ballroom

THE 45 MINUTES

3 min	8 min	25 min	9 min
CONTEXT	WARM-UP	MOVEMENT VOCABULARY	COOL-DOWN

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will explore the physical vocabulary of Harlem Renaissance dance — the Lindy Hop, Charleston, and jazz movement — understanding these not as performance spectacle but as a form of cultural expression, community building, and joyful resistance. They will connect rhythmic movement to musical structure, develop coordination through partner and group patterns, and reflect on dance as embodied history.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **SHAPE Standard 1** — Demonstrate competency in a variety of motor skills and movement patterns in dance contexts
- **SHAPE Standard 2** — Apply knowledge of concepts, principles, strategies, and tactics related to movement and performance
- **SHAPE Standard 5** — Recognize the value of physical activity for health, enjoyment, challenge, and social interaction

MATERIALS NEEDED

- **Audio:** upbeat jazz — recommended: Chick Webb, "Stompin' at the Savoy" (1934); Duke Ellington, "It Don't Mean a Thing" (1932). Both free on YouTube.
- Open gym space or cleared classroom; no equipment needed
- Optional: short video clip of Lindy Hop dancers at the Savoy Ballroom (several authentic clips on YouTube)
- Differentiated reflection handouts — one per student (completed after activity)

CONTEXT · 3 MINUTES · BEFORE GOING TO THE GYM

"The Savoy Ballroom opened in Harlem in 1926. It held 4,000 people. Black and white dancers danced together — which was illegal in many other places in America. The Lindy Hop was born there. It was named after Charles Lindbergh's transatlantic flight in 1927 — people said the dancers looked like they were flying. Today we're going to move the way Harlem moved."

WARM-UP · 8 MINUTES

Jazz walk and rhythm

Students walk to the beat of jazz music. Teacher calls out: **freeze** (hold pose), **slow motion** (half speed), **double time** (double speed), **mirror** (copy teacher's arm movements while walking). Purpose: establishes rhythmic listening and body awareness before structured movement.

CORE ACTIVITY · 25 MINUTES

Movement vocabulary

PHASE 1 · 8 MIN

Charleston Step

Teach the basic Charleston: step forward on right, kick left foot forward; step back on left, kick right foot back. Count 1-2-3-4. Once secure: add arm swing. Once secure: try with partner in mirror.

PHASE 2 · 10 MIN

Lindy Hop Basics

Introduce the rock-step: rock back on left (count 1), replace weight onto right (count 2); then triple step left-right-left (counts 3-and-4) and triple step right-left-right (counts 5-and-6). This is the 6-count basic, the first step most Lindy Hop classes teach. Practice solo, then in loose pairs (not holding hands — just facing).

PHASE 3 · 7 MIN

Creative Response

Students in groups of 3–4. Give each group a card: **Joy / Protest / Journey / Arrival in Harlem**. Groups create a 16-count movement sequence using the vocabulary they've learned that expresses their word. Share with one other group.

COOL-DOWN AND REFLECTION · 9 MINUTES

Slow walk to music cooling down. Ask: *"Where in your body did you feel the rhythm most? What did it feel like to move to music that was made about 100 years ago?"* Students complete reflection handout.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: online at the address below.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

THE SAVOY BALLROOM

Historical notes

Location 596 Lenox Avenue, Harlem, New York

Open 1926–1958

The Savoy was the most famous dance hall in America during the Harlem Renaissance. Nicknamed "The Track" (for its long dance floor) and "The Home of Happy Feet," it was one of the few integrated public spaces in New York — Black and white dancers were equally welcome. The Lindy Hop was developed and refined there by dancers like Frankie Manning and Norma Miller.

The Lindy Hop was named after Charles Lindbergh's solo transatlantic flight in 1927 — a dancer reportedly said the jumps looked like "hops" across the Atlantic. It became the defining American social dance of the 20th century, eventually evolving into swing, jitterbug, and rock-and-roll dancing.

DIFFERENTIATION NOTES

- **Students with mobility limitations:** all movements can be adapted to seated or upper-body-only versions. The rhythm and arm patterns carry the learning objective independently of footwork.
- **Students uncomfortable with partner work:** all phases can be completed solo or in parallel with others — no physical contact is required at any point in this lesson.
- **Extension for confident movers:** teach the "air step" — one partner lifts the other. This requires significant trust and should only be introduced if safety permits and students request it.

CROSS-CURRICULAR CONNECTIONS

- **Music:** syncopation and swing are felt physically in Lindy Hop — dancers feel the accents swing music puts where you don't expect them. PE makes the music theory visceral.
- **Social Studies:** the Savoy Ballroom was an integrated space in segregated New York — this is a history lesson about resistance expressed through joy
- **Science:** center of gravity, momentum, and rhythm as temporal pattern are all physically experienced in partner dance
- **Catholic Social Teaching:** the Savoy Ballroom's integration was a practical expression of human dignity — people of different races choosing to celebrate together when the law said otherwise

ASSESSMENT

- Participation and rhythmic engagement during activity
- Quality of reflection response — depth of connection between movement and cultural context
- Group creative sequence — does the movement communicate the given concept?